

Ian Cowpar

Principal-scope Product Leader · AI-first SaaS · Platform & Adoption · Zero-to-one Builder

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SUMMARY

Product leader operating at principal scope inside AI-first SaaS. Two years owning product across a \$250M ARR enterprise platform serving 300 customers at UKG, including the organization's first organized AI capability layer (built from zero, no top-down mandate) and a zero-to-one product taken from concept to production in a week. A decade prior at Broadridge in compliance-grade financial services, where client confidentiality and regulatory consequence were the operating environment. Originator of the Zero-Translation Building framework, with weekly published thought leadership on AI adoption realism.

SELECTED OUTCOMES

- **Built UKG product organization's first organized AI capability platform.** Scaled shared infrastructure across 20 PMs with no top-down mandate, to the point that multiple PMs built their own custom slash commands and retired manual workflows entirely. Adoption measured by what stopped, not what launched.
- **Shipped a zero-to-one self-serve product from concept to production in a one-week prototype cycle.** Projected ~30% time reduction in a ticket-gated enterprise workflow. Wrote the prototype in Claude Code, scoped three business epics with the platform architect, delivered an engineering-ready package the architect built directly against.
- **Surfaced ~\$50M in at-risk ARR before escalation** through a composite risk model scoring top accounts on exposure, case volume, true-defect rate, and sentiment, replacing raw ticket counts with weighted signal and an automated weekly cadence the program lead acted on.
- **Cut a working defect list from ~200 issues to 5 (~97%)** with an opinionated analytics product, embedding a Claude Code function that routed the single highest-leverage action across five issue panels and four products.
- **Drove cross-functional prioritization across product, engineering, and services without direct authority**, translating customer signal from executive escalation rooms into tradeoff decisions across four product lines on a \$250M ARR platform serving 300 customers.

EXPERIENCE

Senior Product Manager · UKG · Lowell, MA · Jun 2024 – Apr 2026

Principal-scope product ownership across AI capability, zero-to-one builds, and data products serving 300 enterprise customers on a \$250M ARR platform.

- **Built the organization's first AI capability platform from zero**, scaling it across 20 PMs without mandate and coaching individual PMs until they retired manual workflows for their own slash commands.
- **Shipped a zero-to-one self-serve product concept-to-production in one week**, prototyped in Claude Code and scoped with the platform architect, projected to cut ~30% from a ticket-gated enterprise workflow.
- **Owned the upgrade program's data products** — a composite ARR-risk model that surfaced ~\$50M at risk before escalation, and an analytics product with an embedded Claude Code function that cut a defect list ~97%.

Drove cross-functional prioritization in executive escalation rooms across four product lines. Brand Champion, UKG North America Regional Lead 2026; Fire Up ERG (women and allies), Business Innovation workstream lead.

Business Analyst · Broadridge Financial Solutions · Andover, MA · Jan 2014 – Jun 2024

Forty-plus enterprise SaaS deployments end-to-end in compliance-grade financial services, where client confidentiality and regulatory consequence shaped every delivery decision.

- **Led 40+ enterprise SaaS client deployments end-to-end** in a regulated environment where a wrong output had regulatory consequence, not a bug ticket; partnered with engineering on system behavior, data flows, and integration dependencies.
- **Served as internal subject-matter expert for an omni-channel communication product adopted across the entire enterprise client base**, translating complex compliance capabilities into workflows non-technical buyers could operate without support.

Senior Document Development Analyst · Broadridge Financial Solutions · Andover, MA · Jan 2006 – Jan 2014

Built and maintained complex client-facing document and communication systems in a regulated financial services environment.

SKILLS AND FOCUS AREAS

Product Strategy & Leadership: Principal Product Manager-scope ownership, product vision and roadmap, OKR-to-execution, prioritization in ambiguous spaces, cross-functional leadership without direct authority, mentorship of junior PMs, outcomes over output, Agile / Scrum, B2B SaaS

AI as Core Multiplier: AI capability platform building, embedded AI features inside internal products, Claude Code prototyping, twenty custom slash commands and a personal Claude Code productivity OS in active daily use, agentic workflows, AI adoption measurement (extinction over addition)

Technical Credibility: APIs and system architecture, data flows and integration dependencies, deployment-model and platform product thinking, technical-systems fluency with engineering, SQL

Data & Experimentation: Opinionated analytics products, composite scoring and risk modeling, success-metric and KPI definition, hypothesis-driven development, signal-versus-noise routing

Enterprise SaaS: Compliance-grade regulated delivery, client confidentiality as table stakes, enterprise customer escalation-room presence, multi-org program coordination, stakeholder management

Tooling: Jira, Confluence, GitHub, SQL, Claude Code CLI, Slack MCP, Salesforce Service Cloud (operator)

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science, Management Information Systems and Management

Manning School of Business, UMass Lowell · 1999

WRITING AND THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

The Unofficial Leader (Substack) · theunofficialleader.substack.com

Weekly publication on where AI actually earns its place, adoption realism, and what's happening beneath the surface of how teams work. Originator of the Zero-Translation Building framework.